

explained Rahul. Moreover, Amarinder Raja Warring, the candidate who came second to Bittu by 500 votes was shifted to Delhi and made general secretary in charge of five states. "No one in my family is in politics. I would have never been noticed had they not held elections to the IYC," says Warring.

To ensure that the election process meets his manual, Rahul has hired the Foundation of Advanced Management of Elections (FAME), an organisation run by retired chief election commissioners. According to the MOU signed between them, the process will be completed by December 2010 with the election of the IYC chief. The last time an IYC chief was elected was in 1971. "When I met Rahul for the first time in 2008, I put two conditions before him. One was that criminals should not be allowed to enter. Second, the election should be transparent and all disputes be settled by FAME. He agreed," K.J. Rao, general secretary, FAME, told INDIA TODAY. The elected IYC chief of Daman and Diu Mukesh Patel was sacked when it was discovered that there were criminal charges pending against him. "The complaints are sent to us and we send our recommendations to Rahul. He takes swift action," says Rao.

This is also a way of reviving the party at the grassroots level, particularly in states like Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu, where the Congress is non-existent. Rahul's recruitment drive in Tamil Nadu, that enlisted over two lakh members, had even the DMK chief K. Karunanidhi worried that the Congress may want to fight the next elections in the state without an alliance. That is, of course, Rahul's eventual plan. He has made no secret of the fact that he would like to see the party win without alliances that only weaken the Congress' own votebank. The Bihar launch was the grandest so far, perhaps because the state is due to go to polls end of this year. On Swami Vivekananda's birth anniversary (a youth icon from another time) this January, the Delhi-Patna

flight carried 16 young MPs, including Prasada, Sachin Pilot, Milind Deora, Deepender Hooda and Madhu Yaskhi. Each had been given a district in Bihar to launch the membership drive and they all carried the same simple message: the politics of patronage is over. "Earlier the nominations of the IYC chiefs at the district level was done by the state president who would nominate his friends and favourites, who were

systems in place that survive beyond him. He wants to make sure that *yeh charkha jo shuroo kiya hai, aage bhi chale* (he wants the wheel to keep spinning even after him)," says Satav, bestowing subliminal Gandhian grandeur on his young boss.

Nowhere is this classic 'before and after' story best showcased than the IYC headquarters in the Capital. Four years ago, it was a deserted and desolate building. The only sign of communication was a list of telephone numbers for the absentee

A YOUTH CONGRESS RALLY IN KERALA

C SHANKAR



The building blocks are being put in place. Rahul is USING THE YOUTH CONGRESS TO cultivate new talents as electoral assets.

more loyal to the individuals rather than the organisation. Now it is done purely by elections," explains Yogesh Dixit, president of the IYC in Uttar Pradesh.

Well, there are still some glitches. In Tamil Nadu, two powerful leaders are fighting over control of the youth wing with G.K. Vasan, Union minister for shipping, and Karthik Chidambaram, son of Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram, playing camp politics. Yet as Rahul would argue, a process has been set in motion. "Rahul's main concern is to put

office-bearers flapping lazily under a slow-moving fan. Today the office is abuzz with activity. There is an attendance register at the reception. The president's office is full of young men in checked shirts and *kolhapuris* talking earnestly about PPTS (power point presentations) and SHGS (self-help groups). In the age of Rahul, if to be young is to be politically correct, then to join the IYC is to be politically empowered.

with inputs from Amitabh Srivastava, Arvind Chhabra, Subhash Mishra and P. Ramajayam